Introduction

Congratulations! You have joined the growing number of students who have chosen to study GCSE Media Studies and to find out about the fascinating world of the media and its important role in today's society.

What kinds of things do we study?

Your Media Studies course will encourage you to explore a range of media texts: products such as television programmes, magazines, radio shows and films. By learning about how they convey meaning, how they are made and who made them, you can become confident and skilled in making judgements and reflecting on what you have learned.

Do we get to make our own media texts?

Your course will also help you learn by giving you the chance to make media texts of your own; you can find out at first hand what skills are required to create productions that inform and entertain the audiences who will consume them.

Will we have the chance to show what we know?

The good news is that you begin the course with the advantage of having a great deal of knowledge about the media from your experience of the world around you and from your own choice of entertainment – the media products which are all around in everyday life. You will have the opportunity to channel this existing expertise and to use it to produce responses that show what you know, understand and can do.

What variety of texts will we learn about?

This book is designed to provide you with a wealth of examples of media texts to discuss and analyse. In addition, you will find up-to-date information about the trends in the media today. The study of texts from earlier times show developments in technology and changes in the social roles of individuals and groups in society, encouraging you to reflect upon the influences that have shaped our media today.

What about the work we give in?

Advice is given on how to approach both the written and practical work you will be required to submit as evidence of your achievement in Media Studies and which will be assessed for the GCSE qualification for which you are aiming.

Will the activities all be the same?

Everybody has a particular style of learning. Students who are sometimes called 'active learners' tend to retain and understand information best by doing something active with it – discussing or applying it or explaining it to others. Other students prefer a 'reflective' style that allows them to think about a topic quietly. A 'visual learner' responds to information presented in pictures and diagrams.

Everyone can be an active learner, a reflective learner and a visual learner, adopting particular styles at different times. It is therefore important to have a selection of approaches that stimulate and motivate and allow you to be confident about your learning. This book provides activities and tasks that are designed to match different styles and therefore allow you to learn most effectively. These include regular opportunities for discussion, working with visual materials and practical tasks as well as the more formal writing about ideas and facts.

How will we find out what we need to know to do well in our GCSE?

Examination boards produce specifications that are outlines of what is to be covered in the course and how it is to be assessed. The topic areas and activities in this book help you achieve these 'assessment objectives' by matching these requirements. Some of the activities help you explore ideas; others are assignments to be completed for formal assessment. Units 10–15 provide you with suggestions and support for these assignments. Together, they provide you with what you need to do well in your GCSE.

Will we need to know any special vocabulary?

Media Studies, like any other subject, has its own technical terms which are a kind of shorthand for explaining processes or ideas used in the media industry by the people who make products or those who study them. In order to help you with these specialist terms, there are boxes which explain key terms. Sometimes the terms cover key concepts – central ideas that are important in the study of a variety of topic areas.

In addition you will find Tip boxes that will help you to understand what examiners are looking for. Other Tip boxes will give you practical hints, or show you where and how you can do further research on the Internet.

Can we dip into the book at different points?

The design of the book allows you to approach each topic on its own or to follow the order of the units as you prefer. The units start with activities designed to get you thinking, then go into more detail. There are tasks, activities and questions at regular intervals. You will find that some material is covered several times in the book in different contexts – this is because these are important topics that you will need to understand in the first unit you tackle. The final part of the book provides you with lots of ideas for your assignments.

Can we use the Internet for research?

The Internet is a very useful resource for Media Studies. There are links to relevant websites in this book. In order to ensure that the links are up-to-date, that the links work, and that the sites are not inadvertently linked to sites that could be considered offensive, we have made the links available on the Heinemann website at www.heinemann.co.uk/hotlinks. When you access the site, the express code is **9693P**.

What is MediaStage?

MediaStage is a 3D animated learning environment designed for GCSE Media Studies. It is an exciting way for you to explore the key areas of media studies along with developing practical skills in film and television, and demonstrating understanding of theory.

MediaStage is, in essence, a virtual movie production kit where you can choose from a range of pre-made production sets, or even create your own using the range of layouts and props available.



You can choose from a cast of actors who can be placed within the set and animated using a range of gesture and movement instructions. You can use text-to-speech technology to make the characters say their lines, import pre-recorded audio, or use the recording facility to record your own voices for the part.

Once the performance is ready you can set up cameras and lighting. There is a range of editing tools that will allow you to record, play back and then modify your performances. You can bring your own 'real' video footage into your performances, and can also export your finished performances to video tape for more traditional editing.

Why use MediaStage *for GCSE Media Studies?*

By using *MediaStage* you will not only be developing practical media skills, you will also be putting into practice the theories and concepts you have learnt during your course. For example, you might create a narrative sequence to demonstrate your understanding of the five stages of Todorov's narrative theory.

It is not intended that *MediaStage* replaces other technology when you do production work – you will benefit from using 'real' digital video equipment or setting up 'real' photo shoots with live props and models. However, there are a huge variety of ways in which MediaStage can be used in a GCSE Media course, and it can complement other media technologies.



For example, one area where *MediaStage* can really enhance your work is by allowing you to create your 'ideal' sets for a film project. Very often students are limited to filming in, say, the school grounds and are frustrated because they cannot create professional-looking sets. Within *MediaStage* this problem is overcome, and sets can also be professionally lit. Even if you go on to film in a 'real' location, you can storyboard using still shots from *MediaStage* – this will greatly enhance the planning sections of any productions you undertake.



This icon indicates that activities are available in *MediaStage*.

Introduction to GCSE Media Studies for AQA

First of all – welcome to the wonderful world of Media Studies. As the old knight says to Indiana Jones in *The Last Crusade*, 'You have chosen well'. During your GCSE course you will have many opportunities to study areas of the media which you will already know a great deal about. In fact, there can't be many subjects you will begin to study with so much previous knowledge. Part of the fun of this course is that you will learn how to use your knowledge and apply it in theoretical ways.

The Assessment and Qualifications Alliance (AQA) is an Awarding Body providing a Media Studies course that reflects your interests and experiences while at the same time developing your knowledge and awareness of key media areas and issues. What is more, the GCSE course is designed to flow smoothly into the AS and A Level courses for those of you who take the subject to a higher examination level.

Before you start any course of study it is always a good idea to have an overall idea of what that course will involve, what will be expected from you in terms of workload and assessment and what you will have to do to get the best possible grade. To do this you need to understand what **Key Concepts** and **Assessment Objectives** are and what role they play in your GCSE Media Studies for AQA course.

What are Key Concepts?

The Key Concepts form the basis of the subject content of your course. These are:

- Media Language: forms and conventions
- Audience
- Institutions
- Representation

You will study the Key Concepts in detail, but will find that they are not always separately presented – the course will allow you to look at how they work across different media text types, such as television and magazines.

- **Media Language** means the ways in which media texts communicate with people that use them. You may find out about camera movement, editing, and so on.
- **Audience** study turns attention on how people receive these communications. You may learn when studying popular music about how audiences are targeted by record companies, or about the way two papers present the same story when studying newspapers.
- **Institution** study turns your attention to the people who own and make the media texts people enjoy every day. If the area you are looking at is Film, you could find out about how films get to appear at your local cinema and about who decides what certificate they get. Institution in a radio context could be studied by finding out how news is gathered and produced at your local radio station.
- Studying **Representation** allows you the chance to see yourselves and others as the media see you and find out whether you still recognise yourselves. You might find out about the way people from your area of the country are presented on television or how people from different professions appear in films.

What will I be studying?

During your course you will be studying a wide range of media forms. The AQA course offers opportunities to study Television, Film, Radio, Popular Music, Newspapers, and Magazines and Comics: a selection that has something for everyone! You may study all of these, but you only have to cover three. Within these topic areas there are also opportunities to study advertising, cartoons and animation.

Whatever area you have been looking at, the work you will be asked to do will assess your ability to do three things:

1 To know about and understand the media texts you have been studying (known as *Knowledge and understanding*).

2 To analyse and interpret them – that is, think about how they work (known as *Analysis and interpretation*).

3 To make some media texts of your own by learning skills in production such as using cameras or software packages, as well as showing off your creative side by designing front cover pages for texts like fanzines (known as *Production skills*).

What are Assessment Objectives?

Assessment Objectives are the criteria that the Awarding Body, AQA, uses to assess your capabilities. GCSE Media Studies for AQA has three Assessment Objectives that require you to demonstrate:

- Knowledge and understanding (AO1)
- Analysis and interpretation (AO2)
- Production skills (AO3).

Your quality of written communication will also be assessed under Assessment Objectives AO1 and AO2.

How do I get my marks?

The AQA requires you to produce a coursework folder, which accounts for 50 per cent of your total marks, and to complete one written examination (known as the Controlled Test) at the end of your course, which accounts for the other 50 per cent.

What do I have to put in my coursework folder?

One of the great things about GCSE Media Studies is that the coursework you do will be interesting, relevant to *you* and really good fun. You will be creating totally original pieces of work that you can be proud of. There have been some students who have kept their Media Studies coursework to show at University interviews. You need to choose your best pieces in the two sections outlined below.

Section A: Assignments (25 per cent)

In this section you produce three assignments of about 700–800 words each or the equivalent in design and production work (this is much shorter than you realise, and you will probably need to do a few **drafts**). The assignments are equally weighted and at least one assignment must focus on Moving Image (unless the topic for the Controlled Test is Moving Image).

Each assignment should focus on a different *media text type* (for example, Film) and cover all three Assessment Objectives (which are explained above). Across the three

assignments all four Key Concepts should be covered, though each individual assignment is likely to focus on only one or two of the four Key Concepts.

This piece of coursework is your opportunity to use your analytical skills and apply any specialist media terms or even theories that you have learned. The style of this piece is short, snappy and to the point.

Section B: Practical Production (25 per cent)

This section combines a polished, final draft media text/product, with the planning you put into the finished product and a supporting account. The length of your practical production will depend on its complexity, and your teacher will be able to advise you on this. The supporting account should be about 700–800 words long, and explains how you researched, planned and actually made your product with a specific audience in mind.

The production should cover all three Assessment Objectives (which are explained on page 10). You may work on your own, in pairs or in small groups (no more than four per group). As part of the submitted piece, you will need to produce all your pre-production work (such as research, scripts, storyboards, mock-ups and so on) that you used to help you plan your practical production. You will need to show a clear engagement with the *forms* and *conventions* of mass media texts, as well as a clear sense of *target audience* and *institutional* context.

The production itself should be as complete as possible, in terms of the technology that is available to you. However, you do not necessarily need to produce an entire **text**. For example, if individually you were creating a new magazine it would not be expected that you produce the entire magazine; the front cover, contents page and double-page feature for the magazine would be sufficient for assessment purposes. If you were doing the same assignment as part of a group you would need to submit a proportionate number of pages.

This piece of coursework is your opportunity to demonstrate your **research** skills, your ability to adapt and develop ideas and to plan a finished product with a **target audience** in mind. It is also your opportunity to show that you can respond to research by producing something original, using appropriate **technology** confidently and explaining all your decisions.

At the end of this book there are units containing ideas for AQA coursework pieces.

KEY TERMS

Drafts versions of the same piece of writing, getting better as you have it marked and think of ways to improve it

Research the methods by which you can find out about a media form, a subject area, specific text or person: using the Internet, looking in textbooks, asking others

Target audience the group of people, defined by gender, age, etc., at whom a media text is targeted

Technology the use of camera, soundtrack, lighting, graphics, shot construction, etc.

Text any finished piece ready to be shown to an audience. It could be a magazine front cover, the title sequence of a TV show, a film poster, an advert, etc.

A word of warning

No assignment or practical production may cover the topic areas of the Controlled Test, the details of which follow.

What happens in the Controlled Test?

The Controlled Test is 3 hours long, carries 50 per cent of the course marks and tests all three Assessment Objectives (which are explained on page 9). The Controlled Test uses a case-study approach focusing on one main topic. There are a number of tasks on the test paper (usually four) and they will deal with one or more of the Key Concepts. During the Controlled Test, you will need to show an awareness of the historical context related to the given Controlled Test topic area.

You will be entered for either the Higher or Foundation Tier depending on your achievements in class and the standard of your coursework folder. Each test paper is based on the same topic area, though the actual tasks themselves will differ between Higher and Foundation tiers.

How does the Controlled Test work?

You will be given the test paper and any necessary materials shortly after the start of the summer term. You are then allowed to prepare the tasks that are outlined on the test paper. The Controlled Test is sat under supervised conditions, as for a formal examination, at times chosen by your school or college. The three-hour time allowance for the Controlled Test may be divided by your school or college into no more than two shorter sessions, but you will not be able to take the question papers or the answer booklets away with you between the sessions.

How should I prepare for the Controlled Test?

You should research the topic by:

- looking at a range of similar texts
- finding out how texts have changed over time by looking at non-contemporary texts
- drafting answers and noting how long you take to do each question.

What should I do during the Controlled Test?

During the test you should:

- allocate specific amounts of time for each question
- keep a careful eye on the clock
- make points, give examples and explanations based on specific texts
- refer to non-contemporary texts where applicable
- leave enough time to read through your answers.

Final thoughts

If, now that you have read the information above, you still have questions about the structure of your GCSE Media Studies course, you can ask your teacher or visit the AQA website. Your teacher may also show you past papers for the Controlled Test.

You won't regret choosing Media as a GCSE option. It will give you so many skills that will be useful long after you have closed your examination answer booklet and sat back in your chair in that exam hall with a satisfied sigh.

You will continue to be bombarded by media messages throughout your whole life, but with your GCSE qualification (and – who knows? – perhaps A Level too, one day) you will always have the ability to approach any text with a critical and analytical eye.

1 Film

In this unit you will find out:

- how films use narrative devices, such as flashback, and camera techniques to convey meaning
- how audiences classify films by recognising their genre characteristics
- how institutions and organisations promote and regulate films
- how women are represented in films and film posters.

TALKING POINT

- Start off with an instant survey. First each person should write down their two favourite and two least favourite films.
- Now combine your chosen films into two class lists. Do the same types of films – such as adventure, fantasy, science fiction, romantic comedy and Westerns – appear on both lists? Were the same types of films popular with both boys and girls?



Genre

Did you find that it was easy to say what types of films your favourites were? If so, it is because you already know a lot about **genre**. You can also probably tell, from a few seconds of a TV trailer or even from a poster, what genre a new film is likely to be, and you will have certain expectations as a result. What film genre do these three words suggest: *Saloon, Sheriff, Gunfight*? You probably thought 'Western' before you even read the second word! Media producers rely on your ability to recognise genre when they promote new films, to arouse interest, expectation and anticipation.

ACTIVITY 1

1 Work in pairs. Make a table like the one below to show the characteristics of four popular genres: Romantic comedy, Disney animation, Science fiction and Horror.

Genre	Typical setting	Typical characters	Typical plots	Typical props	Typical themes
Romantic comedy		*Young man, young woman*	*They meet, hate each other, coincidences throw them together ...*		

2 Now share your answers with another pair. Add any good ideas that you missed.

In film, exploring the ways in which **genre characteristics** are used to create style and appeal is very important. Films are often a complex mix of genres – known as *cross-genres* or *hybrid genres* – to attract the widest possible target **audience**. For example,

KEY TERMS

Audience people who are consuming a media text

Genre a type of media text with certain predictable characteristics

Genre characteristics or **conventions** the typical features in a text which show the audience what genre it is

Toy Story (1995) seems to be a simple Disney animation aimed at children. However, it also uses the genre characteristics of:

- Science fiction – Buzz is a Space Ranger
- Westerns – Woody is a sheriff
- Adult comedy – the voices of Tom Hanks and Tim Allen deliver witty one-liners.

TIP

You can find out more about any of the films mentioned in this unit from Internet databases via Heinemann Hotlinks.

ACTIVITY 2

1 Look at the poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996) in **1**. What genres are suggested in the poster?

2 Watch a range of film clips or film trailers. How soon can you identify what genre each one fits into, and if it demonstrates cross-genre (hybrid) characteristics? What audiences will each one attract?



1 Poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996)

Science fiction

The roots of science fiction

Literary heritage

Science fiction is a genre that has at its heart some form of technology which is not yet possible, but which could be one day. Science fiction novels were popular long before film was even invented. Early sci-fi novels include *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea* by Jules Verne (1870) and *The Time Machine* (1895) by H G Wells.

Even earlier, Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* was published in 1818 when she was only 21. It was the first horror/science fiction story written by a woman. It told the story of a scientist who discovers how to make a dead man live again, with terrible consequences.

Early sci-fi films

With fantastic worlds, strange technology and almost magical events, sci-fi novels offered rich material for early film-makers. Some, such as *Frankenstein*, have been